

GLOBAL OUTCRY OVER HUNGER IN GAZA

U.S. blames Hamas as truce talks collapse. France says it will recognize Palestine.

By MICHELLE L. PRICE AND JOSEPH KRAUSS

WASHINGTON — As the United Nations and global aid groups sound the alarm of widening starvation resulting from U.S.-backed Israeli food distribution policies in the Gaza Strip, the Trump administration said Thursday it is cutting short Gaza ceasefire talks and bringing its negotiating team home from Qatar to discuss next steps.

The apparent derailing of the talks comes as Israel's blockade and military offensive have driven Gaza to the brink of famine, according to aid groups. The U.N. food agency says nearly 100,000 women and children are suffering from severe, acute malnutrition, and the Gaza Health Ministry has reported a rise in hunger-related deaths.

British Prime Minister Keir Starmer said he would hold an emergency call Friday with officials from Germany and France to discuss how to urgently get food to people in need and pursue a plan to build a lasting peace.

"The suffering and starvation unfolding in Gaza is unspeakable and indefensible," he said in a statement. The three European countries "all agree on the pressing need for Israel to change course and allow the aid that is desperately needed to enter Gaza without delay."

[See Gaza, A4]



KHAMES ALREFI Anadolu

PALESTINIANS gather to receive meals in Gaza, where a rise in hunger-related deaths has been reported.

Pros, cons of Edison's fire offer

Plan could pay victims quicker but less, and aid state wildfire fund

By MELODY PETERSEN

Southern California Edison's plans to compensate Eaton fire victims for damage were met with skepticism Thursday from lawyers representing Altadena residents, but drew tentative support from others who say the initiative could help shore up the state's \$21-billion wildfire fund.

The utility announced its Wildfire Recovery Compensation Program this week, saying it would be used to quickly pay victims, including those who were insured, while avoiding lengthy litigation.

The announcement comes as state officials consider ways to shore up the state's fund to compensate wildfire victims, amid fears that it could be fully exhausted by Eaton fire claims. Fees that attorneys receive as part of victim settlements could further strain the fund.

State Sen. Henry Stern (D-Calabasas) said Edison's new program

may have some merit as potentially "a more efficient way" than lawsuits to make sure victims are fairly compensated.

He pointed out that lawyers were "coming across the country to represent" Eaton fire victims. "Are they really getting their money's worth when they pay 30% to these lawyers?" Stern asked.

Mark Toney, executive director of the Utility Reform Network, said Edison's program had the potential to reduce costs that otherwise must be covered by the wildfire fund, which was established in part by a surcharge on the bills paid by customers of Edison, Pacific Gas & Electric and San Diego Gas & Electric.

"If Edison is determined to be the cause of the fire, anything they can settle early reduces the costs that otherwise would be paid later," Toney said.

The utility has released few details of how the program would work, leaving victims who are already cop-

ing with uncertainty with more questions. And lawyers who had been seeking to represent victims in lawsuits against Edison were quick to urge caution.

"Without admitting fault or providing transparency, Edison is asking victims to potentially waive their rights," said Kiley Grombacher, one of dozens of lawyers involved in litigation against Edison for the Jan. 7 wildfire that killed 19 and destroyed 9,000 homes in Altadena.

According to Edison, the program would be open to those who lost homes or businesses as well as renters who lost property. It would also cover those who were harmed by smoke, suffered physical injuries or had family members who died.

"People can file a claim even if they are involved in active litigation," said Kathleen Dunleavy, an Edison spokeswoman.

Dunleavy said the company would be releasing more information [See Edison, A8]

Immigrants struggle to manage heat

For the last 16 years, Isabel has worked harvesting carrots, lemons and grapes in the Coachella Valley.

The undocumented mother of three — who, like others The Times spoke with, declined to give her last name out of fear for her family's safety — says the heat in recent summers has been increasingly difficult to manage.

And now, with fewer workers showing up due to fears of ongoing immigration enforcement raids across California, Isabel says she and those who remain have to endure fewer breaks and more physical strain.

Crews that once numbered five groups of 18 workers each are down to three groups of 18. The demands, however, haven't changed.

"You have to pack so many boxes in a day," Isabel said in Spanish. "If it takes you a while to get water, you'll neglect the boxes you're packing. You have to put in more effort."

California's outdoor heat standard — which applies to all workers, legal or undocumented — guarantees breaks for shade and water.

[See Heat, A8]

Fear of federal raids has families and workers facing sweltering conditions, inside and out

By Marcos Magaña



ALLEN J. SCHABEN Los Angeles Times

FARMWORKERS in San Jacinto are told their rights by a legal center rep.

State's Democrats eye district remap to counter Texas

By SEEMA MEHTA

California Democrats led by Gov. Gavin Newsom may upend the state's mandate for independently drawn political districts as part of a brewing, national political brawl over the balance of power in Congress and the fate of the aggressive, right-wing agenda of President Trump and the GOP.

The effort being considered by state Democratic leaders is specifically intended to reduce the number of Republicans in California's congressional delegation, retaliation for the ongoing actions by GOP leaders in Texas to unseat Democratic representatives in its state, reportedly at Trump's behest.

"I think this whole thing is a horrible idea all the way around ... and I don't think people fully understand the ramifications of what they're talking about," said

Republican redistricting expert Matt Rexroad. "Once we get to the point where we're just doing random redistricting after every election ... redistricting won't be used as a tool to reflect voter interests. It will be used to just bludgeon minority political interests, whether it be Republican or Democrat, after every election."

Newsom already has been in talks with Democratic legislative leaders and others about reconfiguring California's congressional district boundaries before the 2026 election.

Doing so probably would require a statewide ballot measure to scrap or temporarily pause the voter-approved, independent California Citizens Redistricting Commission charged with drawing the boundaries of congressional districts based on logical geography, shared interests, representation for minority communities [See Redistricting, A6]

Abuse, squalor in Salvadoran prison

Venezuelan deported by U.S. recalls regular beatings and horrific conditions in custody.

By KATE LINTHICUM AND MERY MOGOLLÓN

CARACAS, Venezuela — When Jerce Reyes Barrios and other Venezuelan deportees entered a maximum security prison in El Sal-

vador in the spring, he said guards greeted them with taunts.

"Welcome to El Salvador, you sons of bitches," Reyes Barrios said the guards told them. "You've arrived at the Terrorist Confinement Center. Hell on earth."

What followed, Reyes Barrios said, were the darkest months of his life. Reyes Barrios said he was regularly beaten on his neck, ribs and head. He and other prisoners were given little food

and forced to drink contaminated water. They slept on metal beds with no mattresses in overcrowded cells, listening to the screams of other inmates.

"There was blood, vomit and people passed out on the floor," he said.

Reyes Barrios, 36, was one of more than 250 Venezuelans sent to El Salvador from the U.S. in March after President Trump invoked the 1798 Alien Enemies Act [See El Salvador, A6]

Judges uphold ruling on bullets

The 9th Circuit decision in effect nullifies a 2016 ballot measure meant to beef up the state's strict gun laws. CALIFORNIA, B1

Tracking money from fire benefits

FireAid's concerts raised \$100 million. Organizers detail where the funds are going. ENTERTAINMENT, E1

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Wrestler, icon Hulk Hogan dies

Terry Gene Bollea, a fan favorite, became a pop culture icon in the '80s and courted controversies outside the ring. He was 71. SPORTS, B6

Weather

Mostly sunny. L.A. Basin: 79/61. B6

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